



FREE GUIDE · FOR NEW & ASPIRING COACHES

How to Start a Personal Training Business

A practical, no-fluff walkthrough of getting qualified, setting up legally, pricing your services, and landing your first paying clients, built for the Australian fitness industry.

Who this guide is for

This is written for two kinds of people: someone who has just finished (or is finishing) their fitness qualification and has no idea what happens next, and someone already training clients casually who wants to turn it into a real business. Either way, the goal here is the same: give you the actual sequence of decisions, in the order you'll need to make them, without the fluff.

This isn't a motivational pitch about following your passion. It's the operational side: what you need on paper, what you need to charge, and what you need in place before your first client walks in. Where something genuinely depends on your situation (your state, your niche, your budget) we'll say so rather than pretend there's one right answer.

A NOTE ON ACCURACY

Qualification pathways, registration bodies, and insurance requirements can change, and rules vary slightly by state. Treat the specifics in this guide as a strong starting point, then confirm current details with AUSactive (the national exercise professional body) or your registration body before you commit money.

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Every step from this guide, in one page

In Australia, the standard entry pathway into personal training is the **Certificate III in Fitness** followed by the **Certificate IV in Fitness**. Certificate III qualifies you to work as a gym instructor; Certificate IV is what actually qualifies you to call yourself a personal trainer and design programmes independently. The qualification itself (SIS30321 / SIS40221) is standardised nationally: what differs between providers is price, delivery style, campus location, and how much hands-on practical support you actually get along the way.

Where to study

A few providers worth knowing about:

- ✓ **TAFE** (state-based: TAFE NSW, TAFE Queensland, TAFE SA, South Metropolitan TAFE in WA, and others), usually the most affordable pathway, and Cert III/IV in Fitness has qualified for **Fee-Free TAFE** places in several states. The federal government has signalled it intends to keep fee-free TAFE running as an ongoing, permanent program, though the eligible course list and number of places vary by state and change over time, so check current availability directly with your state's TAFE.
- ✓ **The Australian Institute of Fitness (AIF)**, the largest private fitness education provider in the country, with campuses in most capital cities plus online delivery.
- ✓ A number of smaller private RTOs and fitness colleges also offer both certificates, often with a narrower regional or online-only focus.

Online vs on-campus vs blended

Most providers now offer some mix of the three. It's worth knowing what you're actually signing up for:

Online / self-paced

Study the theory on your own schedule, which suits people working another job while they qualify. It demands real self-discipline, and Certificate IV still requires supervised practical assessment (running real training sessions, assessed in person), so no provider can make that part fully remote, whatever the marketing implies.

On-campus

A fixed timetable, hands-on coaching practice from day one, and direct access to trainers and assessors. Less flexible around an existing job, and usually ties you to a specific location.

Blended (the most common option)

Online theory modules paired with scheduled in-person practical days or workshops. Gives you the flexibility of online study without losing the supervised hands-on component the qualification actually requires.

Get Qualified

Registering as an exercise professional

Once qualified, the next step most coaches take is registering with **AUSactive** (the national industry body for exercise professionals, formerly Fitness Australia). Registration isn't legally compulsory everywhere, but in practice most gyms, insurers, and increasingly clients themselves expect to see it. It signals you're held to a professional code of conduct and gives you a public, checkable credential.

Insurance and first aid

Two things you'll need in place before you train anyone, paid or not:

- ✓ **Professional indemnity and public liability insurance:** covers you if a client is injured or claims your advice caused harm. Most registration bodies and gyms will ask to see proof before letting you work.
- ✓ **Current CPR and first aid certification:** a legal and practical requirement almost everywhere you'll work, and one insurers check.

Specialising early vs staying general

You don't need a specialisation to start. Most new PTs spend their first year or two training a broad mix of clients (general strength and fat loss goals) before a niche finds them, based on who they enjoy working with and get the best results with. If you do want to specialise early (pre/post-natal, older adults, athletic performance, rehab-adjacent work) most of these require an additional certification on top of Cert IV, and it's worth checking client demand in your area before you invest in one.

WATCH OUT FOR

Some “weekend PT certification” courses marketed heavily online aren't recognised by AUSactive or accepted by insurers and gyms in Australia. If a course doesn't map to the SIS30321 (Cert III) or SIS40221 (Cert IV) training package, confirm it's actually recognised before you pay for it.

Choose Your Business Model

“Starting a PT business” means different things depending on the model you pick, and the model changes almost everything downstream: how you're paid, what insurance you need, and how much admin lands on you. Here are the five common paths.

Employed at a gym or studio

Lowest risk, steadiest income

- Paid under one of a few common structures. See the next page for how these actually differ.
- The gym typically handles bookings, some marketing, and facility costs.
- Good for building experience and a client base before going independent.

Independent contractor (renting space)

Coaches ready to keep more of what they earn

- You pay a facility a rent or session fee to train your own clients there.
- You keep the rest of what you charge, but you handle your own bookings, contracts and marketing.
- Requires your own ABN, insurance and a written space-rental agreement.

Mobile / outdoor PT

Low overhead, high flexibility

- You bring the session to the client (their home, a local park).
- Minimal fixed costs, but travel time limits how many sessions you can fit in a day.
- Check local council rules if you plan to train groups in public parks, since some require a permit.

Online coaching

Coaches wanting to scale beyond hours-for-dollars

- You program and check in remotely rather than running live sessions.
- Removes the ceiling on how many clients one person can serve, but retention and communication become the whole job.
- Needs a genuinely good app for programming, check-ins and messaging: this is where online coaching lives or dies.

Open your own studio

Experienced coaches ready to manage a team

- Highest income ceiling, but also the highest fixed costs and risk (lease, equipment, staff).
- Usually makes sense only after you've already built a client base you can bring with you.
- Almost always requires a company structure rather than trading as a sole trader.

How Gym-Based Trainers Actually Get Paid

If you're training out of an existing gym or studio, whether technically “employed” or a “contractor,” there are a few common pay structures, and the difference matters a lot for your take-home income.

Wage or salary (genuine employment)

A fixed hourly rate or salary. If you're a genuine employee rather than a contractor, this normally comes with superannuation and leave entitlements too. Lowest income ceiling of the options here, but the most predictable, with the least business risk sitting on you.

Percentage / revenue share

The gym keeps an agreed cut of what each session earns, and you keep the rest. The split varies a lot by gym and by who actually brought the client in: a gym-sourced lead is usually split less favourably for the trainer than a client you brought yourself. No fixed cost in a quiet week, but the gym takes a slice of every dollar you earn, indefinitely.

Rent / licence fee

You pay the facility a flat, regular fee (weekly or monthly) for access to the space and equipment, and keep everything you charge your clients yourself. Highest earning ceiling of the three, but you owe the rent whether you trained five clients that week or none. It suits coaches who already have some client volume, not a standing start.

KNOW WHICH ONE YOU'RE ACTUALLY SIGNING

“Employed” and “contractor” get used loosely in this industry. Confirm whether you'll be a genuine legal employee (with super and leave) or a contractor invoicing under your own ABN (with neither). It changes your tax position and entitlements regardless of which pay structure above applies.

MOST COACHES DON'T PICK ONE FOR LIFE

It's common to start employed, move to independent contracting once you have a client base, and add an online component later. Pick the model that fits where you are today, not where you hope to be in five years.

Legal & Business Setup

Register an ABN

If you're going to invoice anyone directly (as a contractor, mobile PT, or online coach) you need an **Australian Business Number (ABN)**. It's free to register through the Australian Business Register and usually takes minutes online. Most new solo PTs start as a **sole trader**, the simplest structure, with the least paperwork, though it means your business and personal finances (and liability) aren't legally separate. A **company structure** is worth discussing with an accountant once you're hiring, opening a studio, or your income has grown enough that the liability separation and tax treatment start to matter.

GST

You only need to register for GST once your business turns over \$75,000 or more a year (or you expect it to). Below that threshold it's optional. Get this wrong in either direction and it's an easy, cheap fix with an accountant, but check it early rather than a year in.

Contracts and waivers

Two documents you should have before your first paid session, not after:

- ✓ **A client agreement / terms of service:** covers payment terms, cancellation policy, what happens if a client wants to pause or refund.
- ✓ **A physical activity readiness / liability waiver:** has the client disclose relevant health information and acknowledge the risks of exercise. Doesn't remove your duty of care, but it's standard practice and something insurers expect to see.

Templates exist, but it's worth having a solicitor or your insurer review whatever you use rather than copying something you found online verbatim: the details that protect you are usually in the specific wording.

Handling client data

If you're collecting health information, payment details or even just contact details digitally, you have obligations under the Australian Privacy Principles once your turnover passes the small business threshold (and it's good practice regardless of turnover). In practice this mostly means: store client data somewhere secure rather than a shared spreadsheet, and be clear with clients about what you collect and why.

Price Your Services

Underpricing is the single most common mistake new PTs make, usually out of fear of losing clients before they've had any. The fix isn't a formula so much as a sequence of questions, worked through in order.

1. Start from your floor, not the market average

Work out the minimum you need per session to make the business viable once you account for: the cost of the space (rent, gym fee, or travel time), your insurance and registration, tax you'll owe as a sole trader (a rough rule of thumb is to set aside 25–30% of profit), and the hours you'll actually be paid for versus hours spent on admin and marketing that you won't.

2. Then look at the market, but don't anchor to the bottom

Look at what comparable coaches charge in your area and for your experience level, but treat the lowest prices you find as a warning sign rather than a target: they're often unsustainable prices set by coaches who haven't done step one.

3. Package sessions rather than selling one at a time

Single sessions are the hardest thing to sell and the easiest for a client to cancel out of. Most sustainable PT businesses run on packages (a block of 8–12 sessions, or a monthly programme fee) paid upfront or via recurring billing. It gives you predictable income and gives the client a reason to commit past week one.

4. Raise prices for new clients before you raise them for existing ones

You can always grandfather existing clients at their current rate for a period while new enquiries come in at a higher one. This avoids the awkward conversation of raising prices on someone mid-package, while still correcting an underpriced offer going forward.

A ROUGH GUT CHECK

If you've never once had a prospective client hesitate at your price, it's probably too low. Some hesitation is a sign you're pricing for value rather than for fear of losing the sale.

Get Your First Clients

Almost nobody fills a diary through Instagram posts alone in month one. The coaches who get to a full client load fastest usually stack several of these at once rather than betting everything on one channel.

If you're going solo, get comfortable training for free at first

If you're employed at a gym, the gym hands you a steady trickle of walk-in leads. If you're going solo instead, whether mobile, online, or renting your own space, that pipeline doesn't exist yet, and nobody builds it for you. Most successful solo PTs spend their first few weeks training a small number of people for genuinely free, not as a permanent discount but as a deliberate choice: it buys you real results, real testimonials, and people willing to refer you, before you've asked anyone to pay you anything. Treat it as an investment with a clear end date (a set number of weeks, or a set number of clients), not an open-ended arrangement.

Start with people who already trust you

Friends, family, past gym-floor clients, teammates from your own training: a direct, personal message asking if they (or someone they know) wants to train with you outperforms almost any cold marketing when you're starting from zero. Offer a genuinely useful intro rate for your first handful of clients in exchange for a testimonial and referrals once they see results.

Make referrals an actual system, not a hope

Ask every client directly, at the point they're happiest with their progress, whether they know someone else who'd benefit from training. Most coaches only ask this once, if at all. Build it into a recurring habit (every 6–8 weeks) rather than a one-off.

Partner locally before you advertise widely

Local physios, chiropractors, and sports stores see the exact people who need a PT and don't compete with you. A simple cross-referral relationship (you send them clients who need clinical care, they send you clients ready to train) costs nothing and compounds over time.

Use content to build trust, not just reach

Posting consistently matters less than posting things that make a specific person think “this coach clearly knows what they're talking about.” Educational content that demonstrates real expertise (how you actually assess and program, not generic tips) tends to convert better than volume alone.

Run a low-friction first offer

A short, cheap or free trial period (a single session, or a week of check-ins for online coaching) removes the biggest barrier for someone who's on the fence: risk. Just make sure the trial is genuinely representative of what working with you is like, so it converts rather than just giving away free sessions.

Systems You Need Day One

It's tempting to cobble together a free calendar app, a notes app for programming, a separate payment link, and a spreadsheet for tracking clients. It works for approximately your first five clients. Past that, the time you lose stitching disconnected tools together starts costing more than any software would.

At minimum, you need a reliable way to handle each of these, whether that's one connected platform or several tools you're comfortable managing separately:

- ✓ **Bookings and scheduling:** clients can see your availability and book themselves, without a back-and-forth message thread.
- ✓ **Payments:** recurring billing for packages, not just one-off payment links you have to chase manually.
- ✓ **Programming:** a proper way to build, assign and update training programmes, not a static PDF you rewrite from scratch every time.
- ✓ **Client communication and check-ins:** a single thread per client, not a mix of texts, DMs and emails.
- ✓ **Progress tracking:** somewhere to log weights, measurements and adherence so you (and the client) can actually see the trend.

This is exactly the gap Totality was built to close: one platform for programming, bookings, payments and client messaging, so you're not paying for and switching between four separate apps. It's not the only way to solve this (plenty of coaches run a good business on a well-chosen stack of separate tools) but if you're setting up from scratch, it's worth trying before you build your own patchwork.

DON'T OVER-INVEST BEFORE YOU NEED TO

Free trials exist on almost every piece of software in this category. Use them. Don't commit to a year of an expensive platform before you've trained your first paying client.

Common First-Year Mistakes

None of these are fatal on their own. Most PT businesses that fail in year one are usually dealing with two or three of these at once.



Underpricing to win the first few clients

It's far harder to raise prices on an existing client than to start slightly higher and grow into it. See Chapter 4.



No contract or waiver in place

One injury claim or payment dispute without paperwork can end a new business. Get both sorted before session one, not after.



Treating marketing as a one-off task

Posting for two weeks, going quiet, then wondering why enquiries dried up. Consistency beats intensity here.



Programming from memory instead of a system

Works fine for 3 clients. Becomes unmanageable and error-prone well before 20.



Not tracking money separately from day one

Mixing personal and business spending makes tax time miserable and hides whether you're actually profitable.



Saying yes to every client who enquires

Not every client is a good fit for your style or schedule. A bad-fit client costs more in energy and reputation than the income is worth.

The Launch Checklist

Every step from this guide, in order. Print this page or keep it open while you work through the rest.

- ✓ Complete Certificate III and IV in Fitness through a registered training organisation
- ✓ Register as an exercise professional with AUSactive
- ✓ Get professional indemnity + public liability insurance in place
- ✓ Get current CPR and first aid certification
- ✓ Decide your business model (employed, contractor, mobile, online, studio)
- ✓ Register an ABN and decide sole trader vs company structure
- ✓ Check whether you need to register for GST
- ✓ Put a client agreement / terms of service in place
- ✓ Put a liability waiver / health screening form in place
- ✓ Set up a secure, compliant way to store client data
- ✓ Work out your floor price, then check it against the local market
- ✓ Decide how you'll package sessions (single vs blocks vs monthly)
- ✓ Reach out personally to your existing network for your first clients
- ✓ Set up a referral ask as a recurring habit, not a one-off
- ✓ Identify 2-3 local businesses worth a referral partnership
- ✓ Choose your booking, payment, programming and messaging systems
- ✓ Open a separate business bank account before your first payment



A note from Totality's founder

"I built Totality because I'm a personal trainer myself, and I was sick of running my business through four apps that didn't talk to each other. This guide is the advice I wish someone had handed me when I started: the practical, unglamorous stuff nobody puts in a course brochure."

Taj Donaldson, Founder & CEO, Totality · Personal Trainer

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